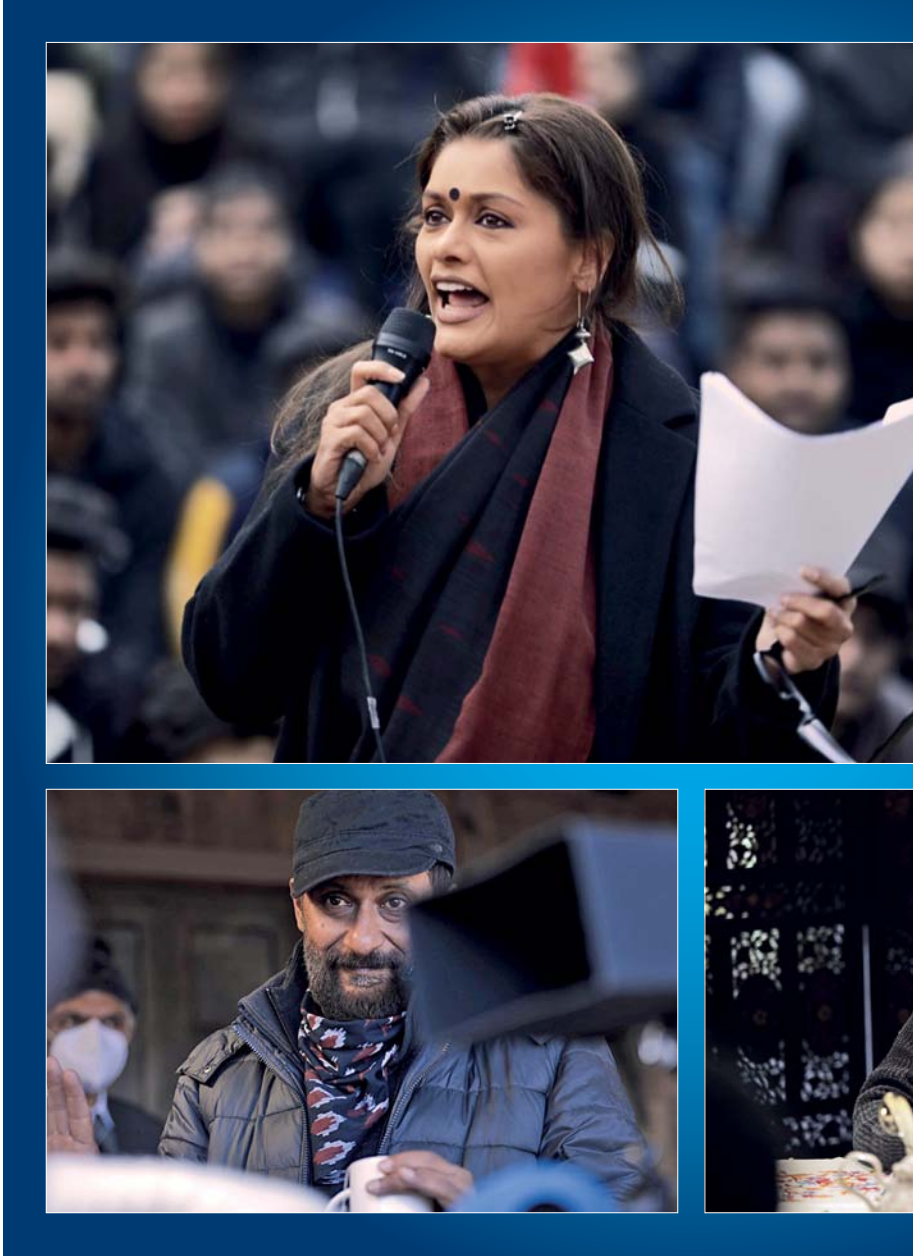


It isn't, however, just a film about the plight of the people who became refugees in their own country. Agnihotri uses the tragedy to launch a broadside against his favourite bete noir: 'liberals', most prominently caricatured here by a professor (played by Agnihotri's wife Pallavi Joshi) who vilifies the government for its atrocities on Kashmir's Muslim majority and seeks to 'appease' Kashmiri Muslim students on the campus of 'ANU' (reminiscent of Delhi's JNU). She's the kohl-eyed, smiling provocateur who sings Faiz Ahmed Faiz's *Hum Dekhenge* and whose favourite word is most likely 'Azaadi'. Agnihotri paints a picture of an academic haven of callous left-wingers who are either ignorant of, or indifferent to, the plight of Kashmiri Pandits.

Audiences have lapped up Agnihotri's political agenda. One of the film's fans is Aditya Dhar, a Kashmiri Pandit better known as the National Award-winning director of *Uri: The Surgical Strike*, which, much like *The Kashmir Files*, confounded expectations and collected Rs 244 crore against a budget of Rs 28 crore. "You might have seen numerous videos of Kashmiri Pandits breaking down in the theatres after watching #TheKashmirFiles. The emotion is real," Dhar wrote on Twitter. "It shows how long we kept our pain and tragedy repressed as a community. We didn't have any shoulder to cry on and no ear to hear our pleas... Being a filmmaker myself, I couldn't have made a better film than this on my own tragedy."

A HATE STORY?

Not everyone concurs though. Some film critics have accused Agnihotri of presenting a lop-sided reading of history. "Mounted like a revisionist docudrama...*The Kashmir Files* is essentially a battle of narratives where Agnihotri has determinedly sided with one version of the events. Employing some facts, some half-truths, and plenty of distortions, it propels an alternative view about the Kashmir issue, with the intent to not just provoke...but incite," wrote Anuj Kumar of *The Hindu*.

Polarised opinions have only fuelled discussion of the film, now a hot topic on WhatsApp groups and news channels. Social media is abuzz with threads on Kashmiri Pandits and Kashmir politics, and trolls attacking negative reviews or reactions. While inflammatory memes proliferated, some people shared a 2013 tweet by the film's biggest star, Anupam Kher, in which he had counselled empathy: "I see some people making Kashmiri Pandit's Exodus outcry into a religious thing. It is NOT. It is about Human Sufferings. Hindu or Muslim. [sic]"

The divisiveness Kher was concerned about has manifested at

BEHIND THE BIG BUZZ

- After opening to Rs 3.25 crore on day one, word-of-mouth publicity, social media chatter and news coverage are taking the film to hit the Rs 100 crore mark in a week
- The film has been made tax-free in BJP-ruled states such as UP, Goa, Tripura, Madhya Pradesh, Karnataka, Haryana and Gujarat. In Assam, the government is granting its employees a half-day leave to catch the 2-hour, 50-minute movie
- Many companies are extending support to the film. For example, the Dalmia Bharat Group has offered to book tickets for its employees and "their spouses (only) in Delhi"